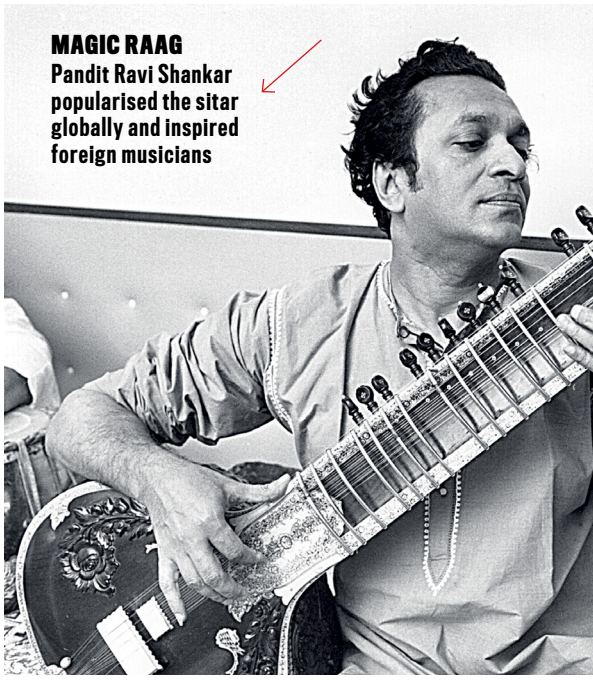
TUGGING AT THE HEARTSTRINGS OF A NATION

The changing face of Indian music from state and later corporate patronage to a market boom of Indipop, remixes and streaming services

By S. Sahaya Ranjit



MAGIC RAAG
Pandit Ravi Shankar popularised the sitar globally and inspired foreign musicians

1947-1950s

As India gained Independence, the original patrons of classical music, the rajas and maharajas, wound up their princely states, leaving musicians to fend for themselves. Musicians realised they had to build their own ecosystem, from creating *gharanas* to cultivating students and creating new public spaces for performances. For many, the government became the new patron, through employment with the All India Radio (AIR). Radio Sangeet Sammelan, which started in 1952, was a pathbreaking programme that helped musicians reach out to audiences across India. **Lata Mangeshkar** had started playback singing in 1947, for the film *Aapki Sewa Mein*, and continued to regale audiences until she passed away in 2022.



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1950s-60s

Ustad Ali Akbar Khan and Pandit Ravi Shankar travelled abroad to showcase Indian music and culture. The popularisation of the sitar by Ravi Shankar inspired many foreign musicians to come down to India and collaborate. Among the other classical musicians who started travelling abroad were

2000s

With the new millennium, classical musicians began to repackage music to suit listeners through collaborations, fusion concerts, Sufi music, etc. The duration of concerts became shorter, from three hours to one hour. The accompanying musicians, notably the tabla player, were now being given due recognition in concerts. Technology enabled musicians to go for pickup microphones to enhance the sound and reinvent instruments, such as Niladri Kumar's Zitar, Kamala Shankar's Shankar Veena, the electronic tabla, etc. Folk music underwent a makeover, the **Manganiyars** being one example.



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2010-2020s

Musicians faced socio-economic challenges as the internet gave easy access to classical music. Music companies began to shut down and musicians struggled to release albums. Challenged by technological advancements, they took to social media and also began releasing singles on music streaming services like Spotify and Gaana. More recently, musicians have also donned the role of organisers of music festivals, creating their own ecosystem to survive.